

"Before state funding is introduced, there should a mechanism to limit corporate donations and prevent black money in polls. Foreign funds must also not be allowed"

– OM PRAKASH RAWAT
22nd Chief Election Commissioner of India

POLITICIANS' LUKEWARM RESPONSE

Most poll observers say there should be a cap on expenditure not just of candidates but also of political parties to clean up electoral finances. "As there is no cap on party expenses, many a time, a candidate's expenditure is shown in party accounts, helping them fudge expenditure reports," says Om Prakash Rawat, who served as the CEC in 2010. One of his predecessors, Naveen Chawla, proposes that a CAG-appointed panel audits the accounts of political parties. Countries such as the US, UK, Canada and Israel impose a cap on party expenditure.

Political parties across the spectrum, however, are not enthusiastic about such proposals. The Union Minister for Environment, Forest and Climate Change Bhupender Yadav believes that putting a cap on expenses is unfair, as political parties have to disseminate their views and ideologies to every nook and corner of the country. Their apparent disdain for transparency was evident when all political parties rejected the Central Information Commission order of June 3,

